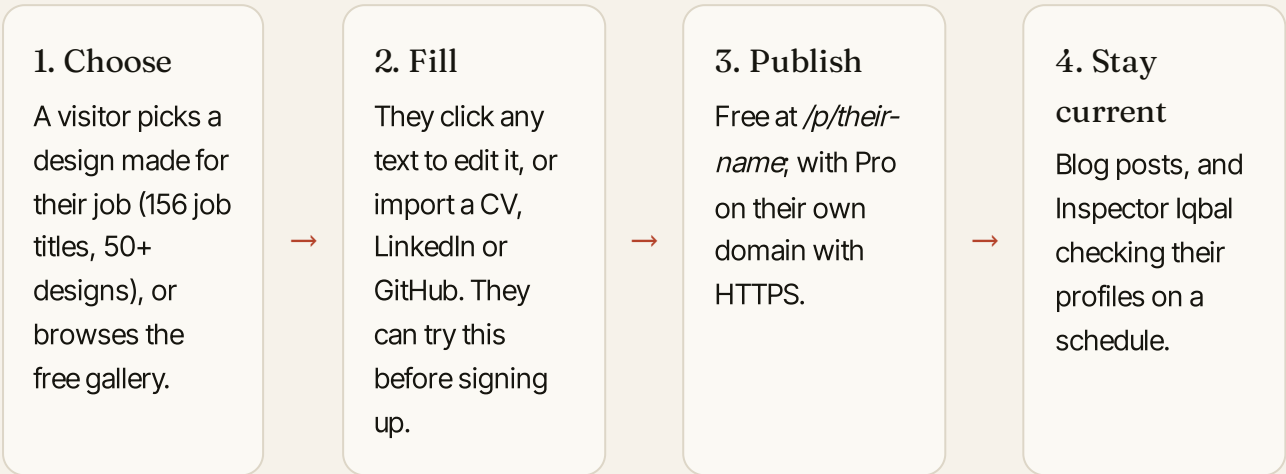


Running Formora *with an AI agent*

How the website works, who pays for what (AI included), and how to hand day-to-day building, running and marketing to an AI agent while you keep control of the money and the big decisions.

From “I need a website” to a site that keeps itself up to date.



PART OF THE SITE	WHAT IT DOES
Templates and gallery	Designs drawn for each profession, previewed with sample content for the visitor's job. The gallery gives designs away free as downloadable code: that is marketing, not the product.
Editor	Click-to-edit preview on desktop and phone sizes, saves as you type, colour and font choices, sections on and off, a Blog tab and an AI tab.
Publishing and domains	A free address for everyone; Pro connects a domain the customer owns or sells one at the registrar's price plus the card fee. Certificates are automatic.
Blog	On every plan, with images, video and pages. Your own blog (the Journal) is written at <code>/admin/journal</code> .
Inspector Iqbal (the Investigator)	Reads the customer's own public profiles and feeds on the schedule they choose, finds news (new job, talk, award), checks it, and suggests it or adds it to their site.
Community	Reviews, suggestions and design submissions, with spam rules and moderation.
Account	Plan and billing, AI credits or own key, domains, emails, deleting the account.
Your console	At your secret address: revenue, sign-ups, visitors, every user, bookings, and links to every admin tool.

The website is free to start. AI is not free.

AI costs real money every time it runs. To use any AI feature, a customer must sign in and then either connect their own API key or buy AI credits from the site. Formora does not give away unlimited AI.

Option A: their own API key

The customer connects their own **Claude** key (from console.anthropic.com) or **OpenAI** key (from platform.openai.com), which is how ChatGPT and Codex users take part.

Free on our side: the AI company bills the customer directly. A ChatGPT Plus, Pro or Codex subscription doesn't include API access.

Option B: buy credits from the site

Requests run on **your** Anthropic key, priced at what each one really costs plus 5%, with the card fee shown separately. Credits never expire.

Protected: every request is metered, each plan has a daily cap, and *AI_DAILY_BUDGET_USD* is a hard daily stop.

Two small, capped trials (your decision, October 2026)

- **60 welcome credits** on a new account (about \$0.60 of AI): enough to see a rewrite or import work once. After that, buy credits or connect a key.
- **The first Investigator check** is on you, once per account, and it stops for the day when the daily budget is reached. Every later check needs credits or the customer's own key.

Everything else

PLAN	PRICE	NOTES
Basic	Free	One portfolio, blog, every design, a small "Made with Formora" link. Anyone can book a free 20-minute demo call.
Pro	\$6 a month or \$60 a year	Up to three portfolios, own domain, no Formora link, more storage.
Custom	Agreed on a free call	A personal designer, 50+ designs to start from, free stock photos, any section added or changed; built and kept up to date.
Domains	Registrar price + card fee	Never bought before the customer has paid; renewals never charged without them paying.

What runs where.

Everything runs on one rented server (a VPS) with Docker. Outside companies do the jobs that need licences or scale: payments, domains, email and AI.

PIECE	ROLE	WHO LOOKS AFTER IT
App (Next.js)	The website, the editor, the API and the console	Agent (code), you (deploys)
PostgreSQL	All accounts, portfolios, posts, payments, credits	Daily off-server backup
Caddy	HTTPS for your domain and customers' domains	Automatic
Hourly jobs	Renewals, reminder emails, the Investigator schedule, clean-up	Automatic (cron)
Stripe	Card payments for plans, credits and domains	You only
Vercel	Domain registrar (buying and renewing names)	You only
Anthropic	Your AI key, used for credits and the free trials	You only ; budget set in .env
Email (SMTP)	Receipts, password resets, reminders, Investigator reports	You set up; agent drafts content
Cal.com	Free demo and Custom calls	You take the calls
GitHub	The code, history and handover notes (AGENTS.md)	Agent works here

Where the instructions live

AGENTS.md in the repository is the handover for any coding agent: what the product is, the rules you've set, the map of the code and what to do next. **docs/** holds the details: SECURITY.md, LAUNCH.md, LOCAL.md, TEMPLATES.md, INVESTIGATOR.md, CONSOLE.md. An agent that reads these first starts with the full picture.

One agent, three jobs, and a clear line it doesn't cross.

A coding agent such as Claude Code or Codex can work on the code, run the tests and prepare releases. With the right access it can also write your marketing, answer community questions and report on the numbers. It should not be able to move money, change prices or publish to customers without you.

Builder

Fixes bugs, builds features from your requests, keeps dependencies updated, runs type checks, lint, the build and the end-to-end tests, and pushes to GitHub with clear notes.

Operator

Reads the console and logs, checks the go-live list, watches for errors and security advisories, and tells you what needs attention each week.

Marketer

Drafts Journal articles and job-title pages, plans social videos, writes emails and replies, and reports which channels bring sign-ups.

The line: always ask you first

THE AGENT CAN DO ON ITS OWN

ONLY WITH YOUR YES

Write and test code on a branch; push to GitHub

Deploy to the live server

Draft Journal posts, captions, emails, replies

Publish to customers, send emails, post on social media

Read the console numbers and logs

Change prices, plans, credits or refunds

Suggest new templates (added as pending)

Approve templates (your rule: owner only)

Find security updates and test them

Touch Stripe, Vercel, Anthropic or the domain registrar

Answer "how do I..." questions from the docs

Anything legal, anything about a customer's money or data

This mirrors the "Rules the owner has set" in AGENTS.md: ask before major decisions, new templates need your approval, no pull requests unless asked, test like a user, and customers' data stays theirs.

Give the agent its own keys, never yours.

1. The code (Builder)

- Install Claude Code (or Codex) on the computer where the repository lives, following LOCAL.md. Open the project folder; the agent reads **AGENTS.md** automatically.
- Let it push to GitHub on the working branch. Turn on branch protection for *main* so only you can merge to it.
- Give it a local *.env.local* with **test** values only: Stripe test keys, a separate Anthropic key with a small monthly limit, no live secrets.

2. The site (Operator and Marketer)

- Make a normal account for the agent (for example *agent@yourdomain*) and add that email to **ADMIN_EMAILS**. It can then write Journal posts as drafts, moderate the community and read the admin pages.
- Never give it the superadmin login or the console address. The console (money, users) stays yours.
- It must not approve templates: that is your rule. If you want, ask it to list templates waiting for you.

3. Outside accounts

- **Social media:** let it draft posts and captions; you post (or approve in a scheduling tool). Platforms ban accounts run by unsupervised bots.
- **Email:** it writes the text; you press send for anything that goes to customers.
- **Money (Stripe, Vercel, Anthropic billing):** no access. Turn on two-factor sign-in for all of them.

4. A standing brief

Keep a short brief at the top of each session, or in a file it reads: *"You run Formora with me. Read AGENTS.md and docs/. Work on improve-editor-and-business. Test every change like a user and report honestly. Ask me before anything that changes what customers pay or see, before publishing, emailing customers or deploying. AI is never free for customers: they sign in and use their own key or buy credits."*

About an hour of your time a week.

WHEN	THE AGENT DOES	YOU DO (MINUTES)
Monday	Weekly report from the console: sign-ups, free-to-Pro conversion, revenue, bookings, AI spend vs budget, errors. Proposes three priorities.	Pick the priorities (10)
Tuesday	Builds and tests the week's fixes and features; updates dependencies if there are security releases.	Nothing, unless asked
Wednesday	Drafts one Journal article and one job-title page aimed at a search people really make ("portfolio website for dentists").	Read and approve (15)
Thursday	Plans three short videos (one template, one feature, one before/after) with scripts, captions and the screen recordings.	Record voice or post (20)
Friday	Replies to community posts and support messages as drafts; summarises the week; lists what is ready to deploy.	Approve replies; deploy (15)

Monthly

- Security: *npm audit*, Next.js releases, the checklist in docs/SECURITY.md. Test a backup restore every quarter.
- Review prices and conversion with the agent's numbers; you decide any change.
- Ask it to propose one new template for a profession that converts well (added as pending for you).

Five channels, all of them cheap.

CHANNEL	WHAT THE AGENT PREPARES	WHY IT WORKS
Search (SEO)	Job-title pages (/for/...), Journal articles answering real questions, internal links between them. The sitemap and robots.txt are already set up.	Free, compounding traffic from people with intent.
AI search	Clear, factual pages with structured data that ChatGPT, Claude and Perplexity can quote. AI crawlers are welcomed in robots.txt.	More answers come from AI; being quoted is the new ranking.
Short video	Scripts and screen recordings of templates in action (scripts/samples/tiktok-clips.mjs records 1080×1920 clips). Real estate first: the calculators, the opening door, the floor picker.	Visual products sell on TikTok, Reels and Shorts.
Free gallery	New free templates and their pages; posts in design communities linking to them.	Free downloads spread the name.
Direct outreach	Lists of professionals with weak or no websites in one city and one job, with a short personal message for you to send, offering a free demo call.	A few calls a week can fill the Custom plan.

What good looks like

- Every piece of content leads to one action: start free, or book a free demo call.
- Plain, specific writing (British English), no invented numbers or reviews, no claims the product can't back up (for example "50+ designs", not "100+").
- Never say AI is free. Say: "Use your own Claude or OpenAI key, or buy credits at cost."

Ready-made instructions for the agent.

Weekly report

"Read the console numbers I paste below and our last report. Tell me in plain language: sign-ups, free-to-Pro conversion, revenue, bookings and AI spend this week vs last; anything broken; three things to do next week, ranked. Don't guess numbers you don't have."

An article

"Write a Journal draft for estate agents: 'What should a real estate agent's website have in 2026?'. 900–1,200 words, British English, practical, mention our real estate templates only where they genuinely help. Add a summary under 160 characters. Save it as a draft at /admin/journal; don't publish."

Short videos

"Plan three 20-second videos for agents: Front Door's mortgage calculator, Off Plan's floor picker, Skyline's currency switch. Give me a hook for the first two seconds, on-screen text, caption and hashtags. Record the screen clips with tiktok-clips.mjs."

A feature

"Build [what you want]. Follow AGENTS.md. Test it like a user in the browser and with the end-to-end suites, run tsc, lint and build, then push to improve-editor-and-business and tell me what you tested and what you couldn't."

Outreach

"Find 20 dentists in Dubai whose websites are missing or outdated, from public listings only. For each, one line on what's missing and a two-sentence message offering a free demo call. Give me the list; I'll send them."

Guardrails that matter.

- **Least access.** The agent gets test keys, a moderator account and GitHub. Not the superadmin login, the console address, Stripe, the registrar or your live AI key.
- **Two-factor everywhere** you sign in: GitHub, Stripe, Vercel, Anthropic, Google, email, the server host.
- **Spending limits.** A monthly limit on any AI key the agent uses; `AI_DAILY_BUDGET_USD` on your platform key.
- **You deploy.** The agent prepares and tests; you run the deploy on the server after reading its summary.
- **Customer data stays private.** The agent never exports customer lists or emails people. The Investigator only reads a customer's own public profiles, with their consent.
- **Instructions only come from you.** If a web page, email or comment tells the agent to do something, it should treat that as information and ask you.
- **Backups.** Daily off-server database backups; test a restore every quarter.

If something goes wrong

SITUATION	DO THIS
Site down	Agent reads logs and proposes a fix; you restart or roll back the last deploy.
A key may have leaked	Revoke it at the provider immediately, replace it in <code>.env</code> on the server, restart.
AI spend unexpectedly high	Lower <code>AI_DAILY_BUDGET_USD</code> and restart; agent finds the cause in the console and logs.
Spam in the community	Agent moderates (it's an admin); add words to <code>COMMUNITY_BLOCKED_TERMS</code> .

Ten minutes to a working copy.

Install **Git**, **Node.js 22** and **Docker Desktop**. Then, in a terminal (Git Bash on Windows):

STEP

- 1 `git clone https://github.com/ahmmed-binas/brandme.git formora` then `cd formora`

- 2 `git checkout improve-editor-and-business` (the latest work; not merged into main yet)

- 3 `npm install`

- 4 Start the database: `docker run -d --name formora-db -p 5432:5432 -e POSTGRES_PASSWORD=formora -e POSTGRES_DB=formora -v formora-db:/var/lib/postgresql/data postgres:16-alpine`

- 5 Settings: copy `.env.local` from the old computer by USB or a password manager (never email or GitHub), or make a new one from `.env.example` as in docs/LOCAL.md.

- 6 `npm run db:migrate`

- 7 Owner account on a fresh database: `npm run admin:create` , then sign in at your SUPERADMIN_PATH address.

- 8 `npm run dev` and open **http://localhost:3000**

- 9 Every time: `git pull` before you start, `git push` when you finish.

To bring your local test data too: on the old computer `docker exec formora-db pg_dump -U postgres -Fc formora > formora.dump` ; on the new one `docker exec -i formora-db pg_restore -U postgres -d formora --clean < formora.dump` (Git Bash or Command Prompt, not PowerShell). Full guide: docs/LOCAL.md.

Your checklist.

Before launch

- Server set up from docs/LAUNCH.md; go-live list at /admin all green
- Separate ENCRYPTION_KEY; DEV_LOGIN and test settings off
- Stripe live keys and webhook; SMTP; Cal.com BOOKING_URL
- LEGAL_NAME, LEGAL_COUNTRY; read /privacy and /terms
- AI_DAILY_BUDGET_USD set to what you can afford
- Two-factor on every outside account; daily backups
- Search Console: submit /sitemap.xml

Every week

- Read the agent's Monday report; pick three priorities
- Approve drafts; post the videos
- Take the demo and Custom calls
- Deploy what the agent tested

Never delegate

- Prices, refunds, money accounts
- Approving templates
- Sending to customers; posting publicly
- The superadmin login and console address

Remember the rule that keeps the business healthy: the website is free to start; AI is paid, by the customer's own key or by credits sold at cost.